Call & Response

Being sabi isn't memorising words — it's understanding how people communicate. African oral traditions run on call and response: someone speaks, someone answers. Every part of this identity is built from that exchange, and from the melody that makes tonal languages sing.

01 · STRATEGY

Positioning, mission and values

Positioning

For Africans and the diaspora who want to speak — not just recognise — the languages of their families, friends and futures, Over Sabi is the conversation-first language app that teaches the culture inside the words, and is honest about what technology can and can't do yet.

Mission & vision

Mission: help people speak African languages with confidence through real conversation and culturally accurate teaching.
Vision: a world where no one loses their family's language for lack of a good way to learn it.

Respect

For elders, speakers and the languages themselves.

Accuracy

Native speakers are the authority; drafts are labelled.

Warmth

Learning a language is personal. We make it feel welcoming.

Honesty

We say what's tested and what isn't.

Plurality

Africa isn't one place, one people or one story.

02 · EXPLORATION

Three directions, one choice

Chosen

A · Call & Response

An S drawn as two answering arcs; a tone line that traces real Yoruba tones. Warm sand, deep forest, ember. Grounded in how language works, not in decoration.

Not chosen

B · Indigo Cloth

Indigo resist-dye grids and geometric repeats. Beautiful, but it borrows one community's textile tradition to stand for many languages, and pattern-as-decoration risks the stereotype the brief warns against.

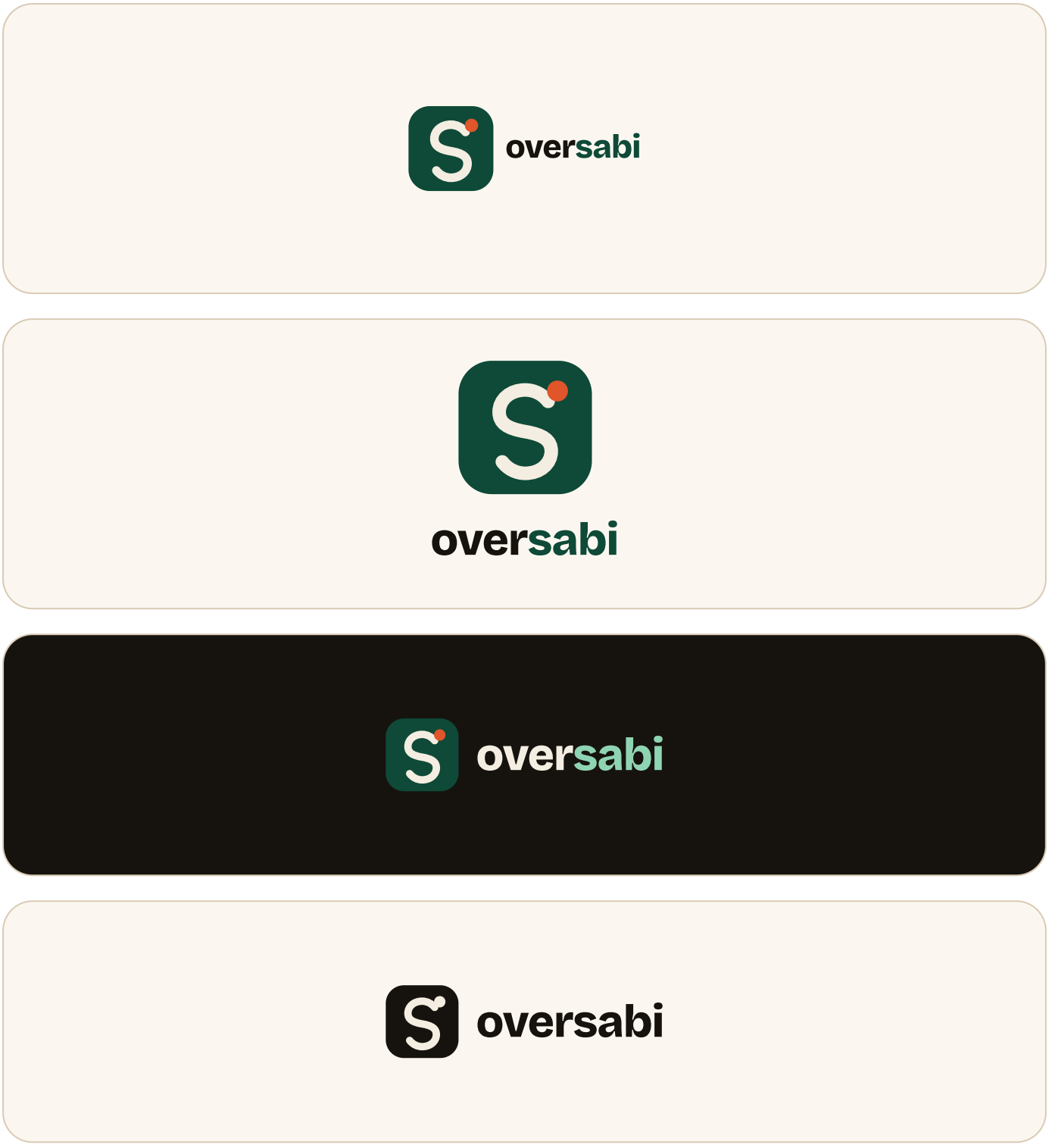
Not chosen

C · Market Signage

Hand-painted shop-sign lettering, bright yellows and reds. Full of energy and very Lagos — too Lagos for Accra, Nairobi and Johannesburg, and hard to make accessible at small sizes.

03 · LOGO

The mark and wordmark



Horizontal (primary), stacked, reversed on Ink, monochrome.

Clear space & minimum size

Keep clear space equal to the height of the ember dot (¼ of the mark) on every side. Minimum size: mark 24 px / 6 mm; horizontal logo 120 px / 30 mm wide.

oversabi

Don't



× Stretch or squash it



× Rotate it



× Recolour the dot to green



× Put it on busy photos

04 · SIGNATURE

The tone line

Our one decorative device carries information. Where text is written with tone marks, the tone line traces the pitch of the words: acute = high, unmarked = mid, grave = low. It's never drawn for text that isn't tone-marked, and never invented.

Ẹ káàárọ̀



M · H · L · H · L

Mo wà dáadáa



M · L · H · M · H · M

Ẹ kú ìrọ̀lẹ́



M · H · L · L · H

05 · COLOUR

Palette

Sand

#F4EDE1
RGB 244 237 225
Page background

Paper

#FBF7F0
RGB 251 247 240
Cards, inputs

Clay

#EADBC6
RGB 234 219 198
Quiet surfaces

Ink

#16130F
RGB 22 19 15
Text, dark sections

Forest

#0E4A37
RGB 14 74 55
Primary: actions, the mark

Ember

#E0552A
RGB 224 85 42
Accent: tone line, highlights

Ember Deep

#B23F17
RGB 178 63 23
Accent as text on light

Indigo

#27306B
RGB 39 48 107
Focus rings, info

Spark

#C8F03C

RGB 200 240 60
Listening state only

Accessible pairs (WCAG 2.2, measured)

Ink on Sand	15.9 : 1	AAA
Forest on Sand	8.8 : 1	AAA
Sand on Forest	8.8 : 1	AAA
Ember Deep on Sand	5.0 : 1	AA
Ink on Ember	4.9 : 1	AA
Ink on Spark	14.1 : 1	AAA
Ember on Sand	3.3 : 1	Large text & graphics only

Pan-African flag colours are not used as a set. Spark is reserved for the "listening" state so it always means "we hear you". Dark mode swaps surfaces to Ink tones and lifts Forest to #8FD4B2.

06 · TYPOGRAPHY

Typefaces

Bricolage Grotesque

Display. Headlines and the wordmark. Variable, OFL licence. Use with restraint: 700–800 weight, tight tracking.

Noto Sans · ẹ ọ ṣ ị ụ ṅ ɓ ɗ ƙ

Body and all target-language text. Chosen because it renders African Latin letters and stacked tone marks correctly. OFL licence.

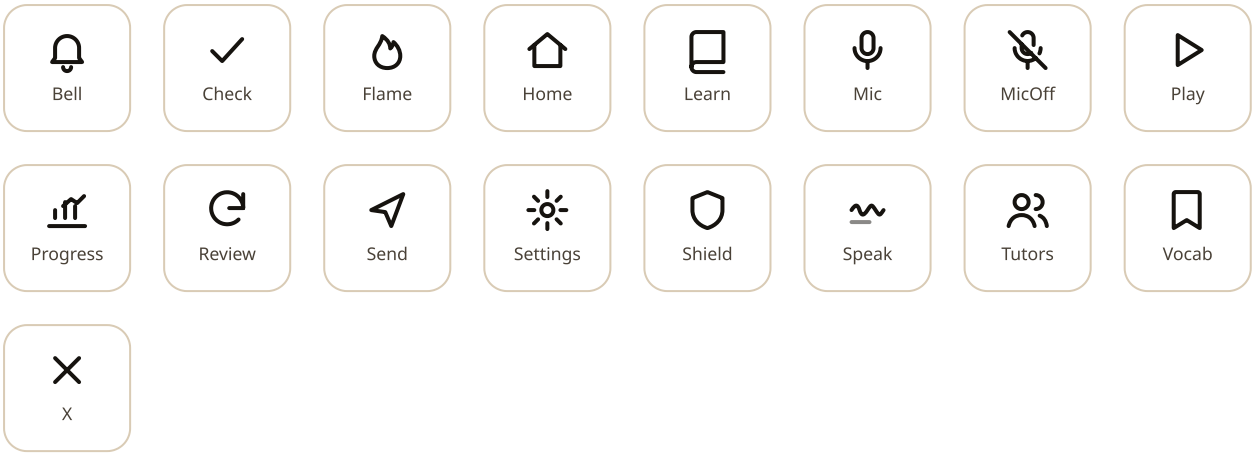
IBM Plex Mono

Utility. Eyebrows, labels, tone legends, data. OFL licence.

Scale: 14 / 16 / 18 / 24 / 30 / 36 / 48 / 72. Line height 1.55 for body; 0.95–1.1 for display. All fonts are self-hosted — no third-party font requests.

07 · ICONOGRAPHY & ILLUSTRATION

Icons and tutors



24 px grid, 2 px rounded strokes, currentColor. Drawn for Over Sabi.



Tutor portraits are abstract and stylised so no one mistakes an AI tutor for a real person. Each wears the tone line as a mouth. Always pair a tutor with the "AI tutor" label.

08 · COMPONENTS

UI building blocks

Primary Secondary Accent Ghost Disabled

Input label

Type here

Hints sit under the field.

Reviewed Draft · awaiting review AI draft Up next

Correct
Feedback is specific and never apologises.



Empty states invite action

They explain what will appear and how to get there.

09 · VOICE

How we sound

We are

Confident, warm, culturally fluent, occasionally witty. Plain verbs, sentence case, specific over clever.

✓ "Almost — check the tone marks. They change meaning."
✓ "You sabi!"

We avoid

Safari clichés, "exotic", treating Africa as one country, fake urgency, invented statistics, over-claiming AI.

✕ "Unlock the secrets of the Motherland!"
✕ "Native-level fluency in 30 days."

Motion and photography

Motion: the tone line draws itself (1.2 s, ease-in-out) when a phrase appears; the listening ring pulses in Spark; the speaking ring in Ember. Nothing else moves for decoration. Everything respects reduced-motion settings.

Photography: real people in real settings — family kitchens, markets, offices, campuses, phone calls home — across many African cities and the diaspora. Natural light, warm grade. No safari animals, no "tribal" costume shoots, no stock poverty imagery. Always with consent and model releases.

App stores: real screens on Sand, one headline per screen in Bricolage, the tone line under the target phrase. Lead with "Speak", then "Learn", then "Keep it".

Social: templates in /brand/social — achievement card (1080×1080) and story (1080×1920). One phrase, its meaning, its tone line.